

6.3 The causes and impacts of international migration

This chapter will explain:

- ★ the types of migrant
- ★ the causes of migration
- ★ the impacts of migration on countries of origin and destination and on migrants themselves
- ★ the different approaches to managing international migration
- ★ detailed specific example: international migration from Mexico to the USA.

International **migration** has been a major process in shaping the world as it is today. Its impact has been economic, social, cultural, political and environmental. Few people now go through life without changing residence several times. How many people in your class have lived in different parts of your country and/or in other countries?



▲ **Figure 6.21** The border crossing between Uzbekistan and Turkmenistan in Central Asia

Migration is defined as the movement of people across a specified boundary, national or international, to establish a new permanent place of residence. The United Nations defines 'permanent' as meaning a change of residence lasting more than one year. Movements with a timescale of less than one year are termed 'circulatory movements'.

[Figure 6.22](#) shows the cumulative migrant stock of each country, using data from the UN Department of Economic and Social Affairs. Currently, about 3.6 per cent of the world's population is living outside the country of their birth. This amounted to almost 281 million people in 2020. The international migrant population globally has increased in size, but it has remained relatively stable as a proportion of the world's population.

Migration is a complex issue. As such, it is one that can be exacerbated by misinformation and politicisation to alarming degrees.

World Migration Report, 2022

The types of migrants

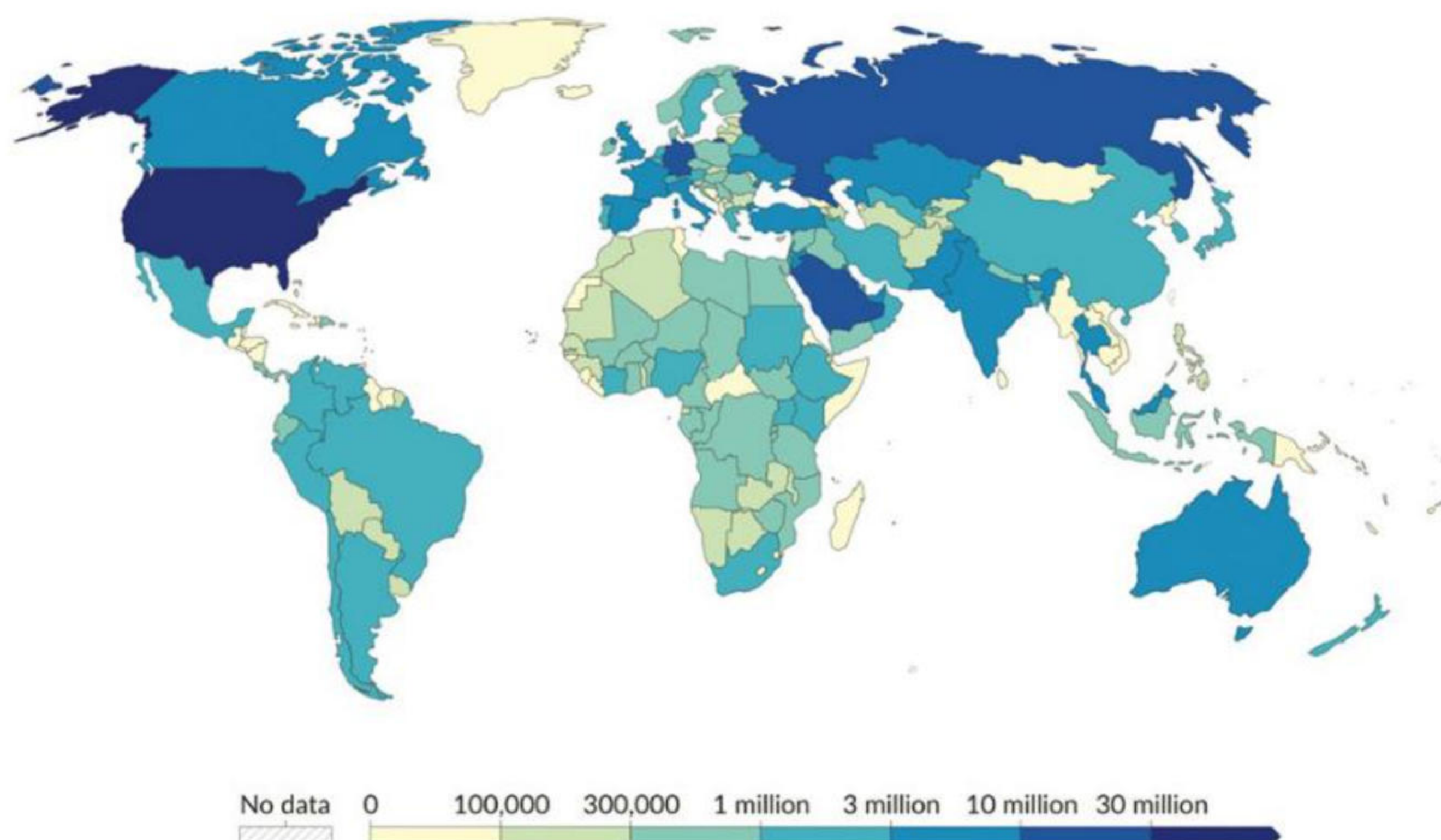
International migrants can be grouped into the following broad categories:

- » Economic migrants: People who migrate with a view to being employed.
- » **Refugees**: People who have been forced to flee their homes because of war, violence or persecution. People who obtain refugee status are given protections under international laws and conventions.
- » Asylum seekers: People who are seeking international protection from dangers in their home country, but whose claim for refugee status has yet to be determined.

In the latter part of the twentieth century and the beginning of the twenty-first century, some of the world's most violent and protracted conflicts have been in the developing world, particularly in Africa and Asia. These troubles have led to numerous population movements of a significant scale. Not all have crossed international frontiers to merit the term refugee movements, but have instead involved **internal displacement**. This is a major global problem and is showing little sign of slowing down. [Table 6.10](#) shows that a total of 89.4 million people were living in displacement worldwide at the end of 2020, up from 84.8 million the previous year.

Total number of international immigrants, 2020

The total number of people living in a given country that were born in another country. This measures the cumulative migrant stock.



▲ **Figure 6.22** The total number of international immigrants by country, 2020

▼ **Table 6.10** The number of displaced persons globally, according to UN category

Displaced persons	Number in 2020
Refugees	26.4 million
Asylum seekers	4.1 million
Internally displaced persons (IDPs)	55 million

Refugees

By the end of 2020 the global refugee population was 26.4 million, the highest on record.

- » The long, ongoing conflict in the Syrian Arab Republic accounted for 6.7 million of the global total of refugees. The impact of this conflict has been huge. Back in 2010, Syria was a **country of origin** for fewer than 30,000 refugees and asylum seekers, while it was also the third-largest host country (**country of destination**), with more than 1 million refugees, mainly from Iraq.
- » As well as Syria, other major source countries for refugees were Afghanistan (2.6 million) and South Sudan (2.2 million). Refugees from these three countries, along with those from Myanmar and the Democratic Republic of the Congo, accounted for over half of the world's refugee population.
- » Globally, 38 per cent of refugees were under 18 years of age.
- » Turkey is the largest host country, with over 3.6 million refugees, mainly from Syria.
- » Seventy-three per cent of refugees are hosted in neighbouring countries. For example, Lebanon hosts a large number of refugees from Syria.

Many refugees are housed at very high densities in huge refugee camps. Apart from immediate problems concerning overcrowding, sanitation and the disposal of waste, long-term environmental damage may result from deforestation and soil degradation. The high cost of refugee camps is financed by the host countries and by international charities.

The World Development Report (2023) highlights the differences between the movements of economic migrants and refugees ([Table 6.11](#)).

▼ **Table 6.11** The differences between the movements of economic migrants and refugees

Factor	Economic migrants	Refugees
Age group	Primarily working age adults	A high proportion of children, some unaccompanied
Origin	A wide range of countries	A limited number of countries (increasingly so)
Destination and	Countries where they believe there is a demand for their skills, often regardless of	Prioritising safety and security over employment. Tend to move to safe countries bordering their country of origin

distance	distance	
Pace	Most economic migrants spend a considerable time planning and preparing to move	Refugee movements are characterised by their suddenness and rapid pace

The causes of migration

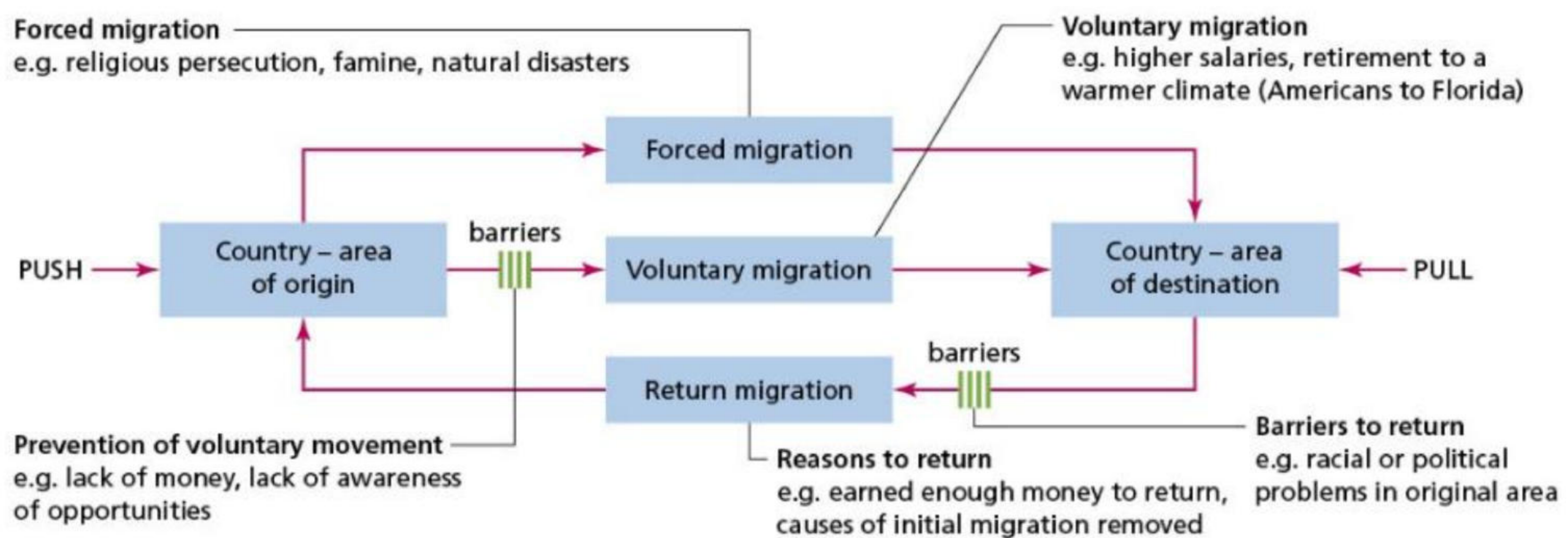
Forced and voluntary migration

A basic distinction is between voluntary and forced migration ([Figure 6.23](#)). **Voluntary migration** is where the individual or household has a free choice about whether or not to move. **Forced migration** occurs when the individual or household has little or no choice but to move. This may be due to environmental or human factors.

Arguably the worst form of forced migration is human trafficking. This involves illegally transporting people from one country or area to another, usually for the purpose of forced labour (modern slavery) or sexual exploitation. Because of the very nature of this practice, high quality data is difficult to obtain, but an estimate published by the International Labour Organization in 2017 puts the total at about 25 million people. About a fifth of this population have crossed an international border.

Barriers to migration

[Figure 6.23](#) shows that there are barriers to migration. In earlier times, the physical barriers ([Figure 6.24](#)) and dangers of the journey and the monetary costs involved were major obstacles. Examples of dangers include crossing seas and oceans or traversing deserts and mountain ranges, when the means of transport were very rudimentary compared to now. The relatively low real cost of modern transportation and the associated high level of safety have considerably reduced these barriers. However, physical geography can still prove to be a formidable barrier for undocumented migrants. Between 2014 and 2020 the Mediterranean Sea saw the highest number of deaths along a migration corridor, where over 21,000 people lost their lives.



▲ **Figure 6.23** Voluntary and forced migration



▲ **Figure 6.24** Iguazu Falls, Brazil: the physical environment is much less of a barrier to migration than it once was

In the modern world, the main barriers to international migration are the legal restrictions that countries place on migration. Most countries now have very strict rules on immigration, and some countries restrict

emigration. Both North Korea and Taliban-controlled Afghanistan place strong restrictions on residents leaving these countries. Wherever they are going, a range of documentation is required for potential migrants to gain entry into another country. Obtaining a visa or a work permit can be a lengthy process.

Demographer E.S. Lee (1966) produced a series of principles of migration in an attempt to bring together all aspects of migration theory at that time. Of particular note was his origins, destination and intervening obstacles model, which emphasised the role of push and pull factors. Here he suggested four classes of factors that influence the decision to migrate:

- 1 Those associated with the place of origin.
- 2 Those associated with the place of destination.
- 3 Intervening obstacles that lie between the places of origin and destination.
- 4 A variety of personal factors that moderate factors 1, 2 and 3.

Lee stressed the point that the factors in favour of migration would generally have to considerably outweigh those against, because people are naturally reluctant to uproot themselves from established communities.

Push and pull factors

Push and pull factors encourage people to migrate. **Push factors** are the observations that are negative about the area in which the individual is presently living, while **pull factors** are the perceived better conditions in the place to which the migrant wishes to go. The greater the perceived difference between origin and destination, the more likely a person is to attempt to migrate. Push and pull factors can be divided into the categories shown in [Table 6.12](#).

▼ **Table 6.12** Examples of push and pull factors

Factor group	Push	Pull
Economic	● Unemployment and underemployment ● Low-paid and insecure jobs, often in the informal sector ● Fragile economies susceptible to high inflation and other economic shocks	● Better employment prospects, with greater job security and higher wages ● Employment more heavily weighted towards the formal sector ● Higher overall standard of living
Social	● Poor housing conditions, with overcrowding and lack of adequate sanitation ● Regions lacking electricity ● Limited social systems – health, education, benefits, pensions and so on ● Desire to find work abroad to provide for family members ● Inadequate policing and justice systems, with high crime rates	● Better housing conditions, with connections to utility systems ● More comprehensive social systems, providing greater security for migrants and their families ● Family reunification – joining family members already at the destination ● A high level of governance and personal security
Political	● Both international and internal conflicts (such as Myanmar or Syria) have caused many people to flee from conflict zones	● The hope of living in more stable political environments or where there is less corruption
Environmental	● The insecurity of fragile environments (food, water and energy) ● Regions prone to natural disasters ● Some world regions are particularly susceptible to climate change ● High levels of pollution (air, water, land) that increase a range of health problems	● Stricter environmental legislation to combat environmental problems ● Higher environmental quality in both urban and rural areas ● People retiring to warmer climates

Demographers view the push/pull discussion as a useful starting point, but as lacking in detailed explanation. For example:

- » Research shows that an individual's social networks, which are neither traditional push nor pull, are a very strong influence on the decision-making of potential migrants.
- » Migration decisions for an individual are often made collectively, at the household level.
- » Demographers now prefer the notion of 'determinants', with a measurable causal influence. This is the objective of trying to be as specific as possible in identifying the causes of migration, for example employment opportunities in the ICT sector in a destination country, and quantifying the number of migrants involved if credible data is available.

Economic migration

Much international migration is economic – that is, people seeking employment in other countries. The rise

in labour-related migration has included both temporary and permanent workers. It has been across all employment categories. Of the major economies, only Japan has not had a significant influx of migrant workers. This is because Japanese governments over a long period of time have been reluctant to accept large-scale immigration, particularly for low-skilled labour. While the inflow of skilled labour remains the priority for developed countries, some countries also welcome less skilled workers, particularly to work in agriculture, construction, care for elderly people, and other business and household services.

Although many migrants rely on family contacts and migrant networks, others may have little choice but to use a company that arranges jobs for people. These companies will try to match a potential migrant to a job in a more affluent country. For example, workers in Bangladesh can pay up to US\$2000 for a job in Saudi Arabia.

However, people also move for other reasons as well as economic migration:

- » Older people retiring to warmer climates, both within the country in which they already live and abroad. A major international example is from northern European countries such as Sweden, the UK and Germany to southern European nations like Spain, Portugal, Greece and Italy. A significant internal migration for retirement purposes is from the northeastern states of the USA to the warmer southern states such as Florida and California. A high level of migration for retirement purposes can have a big impact on the age structure of receiving areas.
- » Medical professionals are in demand internationally, and patients migrate for health reasons. Many countries struggle to recruit enough medical professionals from their own medical schools. They may look abroad to bridge the gap between domestic demand and supply. This is a controversial issue as it may mean attracting staff from lower-income countries, leaving those countries without enough doctors and nurses to meet their own demand.
- » Air pollution has increased in importance as a push factor in migration, because of the medical problems it can cause, particularly for children. Parents, eager to protect a child’s health, may look to move to a safer environment even if this impacts their standard of living.

Activities

- 1 Define migration.
- 2 What is the difference between voluntary migration and forced migration?
- 3 Discuss three significant push factors in migration.
- 4 Suggest how the barriers to migration have changed over time.
- 5 State the difference between a refugee and:
 - a an internally displaced person
 - b an asylum seeker.
- 6 What is economic migration?

The impacts of migration

[Table 6.13](#) is a summary of the possible impacts of international migration. Many of these factors are also relevant to internal migration. Because migration can be such an emotive issue, you may not agree with all of these statements and you may consider that some important factors have been omitted.

The spatial impact of migration has spread, with migrants leaving and entering an increasing number of countries. While many traditional migration streams have remained strong, significant new streams have developed. The great majority of migrants from HICs go to other affluent nations. Migrants from MICs and LICs go in roughly even numbers to HICs and to other LICs and MICs that have stronger economies than their own.

The impact of migration on countries of origin

Remittances

Recent international migration reports have stressed the sharp rise in the number of people migrating to the world’s richest countries for work. Such movement is outpacing family-related and humanitarian movements in many countries. The value of **remittances** these migrants send back has increased considerably over the past 25 years.

- » International remittances totalled US\$702 billion in 2020, of which US\$540 billion went to LICs and MICs.
- » Some economists argue that remittances are the most effective source of financing in MICs and LICs. Although foreign direct investment is larger, it varies with global economic fluctuations.

▼ **Table 6.13** The impacts of international migration

	Impact on countries of origin	Impact on countries of destination	Impact on migrants themselves
Positive	● Remittances are a major source of income in some countries ● Emigration can ease the levels of unemployment and	● Increase in the pool of available labour may reduce the cost of labour to businesses and help reduce inflation	● Wages are higher than in the country of origin ● There is a wider choice of job opportunities

	underemployment ● Reduces pressure on health and education services and on housing ● Return migrants can bring new skills, ideas and money into a community	● Migrants may bring important skills to their destination ● Increasing cultural diversity can enrich receiving communities ● An influx of young migrants can reduce the rate of population ageing	● There is a greater opportunity to develop new skills ● They have the ability to support family members in the country of origin through remittances ● Some migrants have the opportunity to learn a new language
Negative	● Loss of young adult workers who may have vital skills, e.g. doctors, nurses, teachers, engineers (the 'brain-drain' effect) ● An ageing population may be left in communities with a large outflow of (young) migrants ● Agricultural output may suffer if the labour force falls below a certain level ● Migrants returning on a temporary or permanent basis may question traditional values, causing divisions in the community	● Migrants may be perceived as taking jobs from people in the long-established population ● Increased pressure on housing stock and on services such as health and education ● A significant change in the ethnic balance of a country or region may cause tension ● A larger population can have a negative impact on the environment	● The financial cost of migration can be high ● Migration means separation from family and friends in the country of origin ● There may be problems settling into a new culture (assimilation) ● Migrants can be exploited by unscrupulous employers ● Some migrations, particularly those that are illegal, can involve hazardous journeys

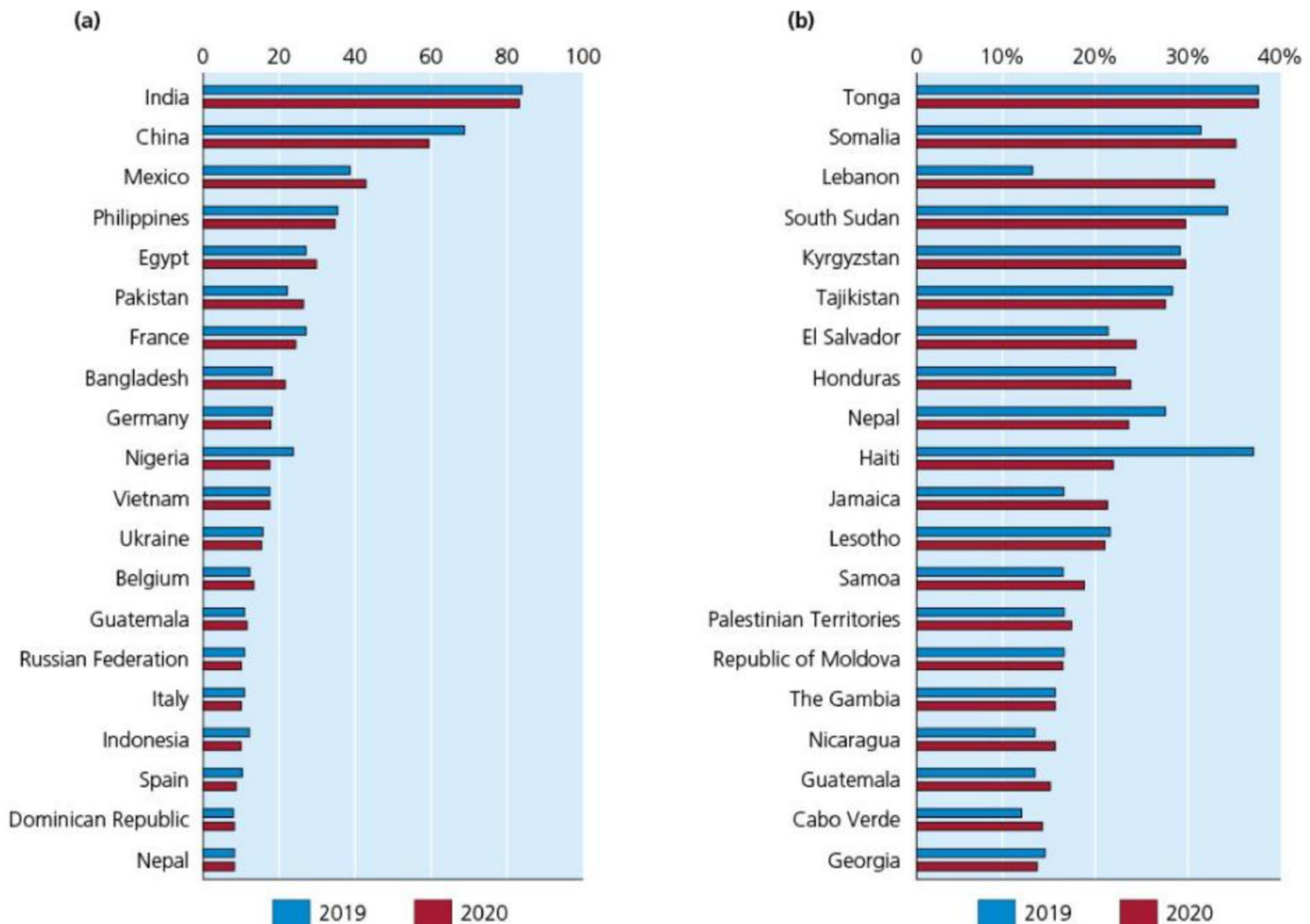


▲ **Figure 6.25** MoneyGram is an electronic money transfer system, by which remittances may be sent

- » Remittances exceed considerably the amount of official aid received by MICs and LICs.
- » Migration advocates stress that these revenue flows help reduce poverty, encourage investment, and reduce the impact of global recession, when private capital flows decrease.

The major sources of remittances are the USA, Western Europe and the Persian Gulf. The top destinations for remittances in 2020 were India, China, Mexico and the Philippines ([Figure 6.26](#)). Dependency on remittances is usually measured as the ratio of remittances to GDP. In 2020 there were 29 countries (out of 177 countries reported) that had a remittance-to-GDP ratio above 10 per cent. However, there are concerns that a heavy reliance on remittances can:

- » create a culture of dependency, potentially reducing participation in the labour force
- » make a country vulnerable to significant changes in the level of remittances.



▲ **Figure 6.26** The top 20 recipient countries/territories of international remittances, by total in \$US billion (a) and share of GDP (b), 2019–20

Other potential advantages of emigration

Other possible advantages of emigration include reducing population pressure on resources such as food and water, and lowering levels of unemployment and underemployment, which are all major problems in many LICs. Emigration can also reduce pressure on the housing stock and on key services such as health and education, which are areas of heavy expenditure for LICs. The links that migrants maintain with their home communities can also help to develop new skills and technologies, particularly when migrants return home permanently and establish new businesses.

Diaspora

The word '**diaspora**' describes the dispersal of a people, originally belonging to one country, around the world. Significant diaspora populations from many countries of origin have been established in many receiving countries. For example, the 20 million people who make up the Indian diaspora are scattered over 135 countries. The Indian diaspora ([Figure 6.27](#)) is comprised of people of Indian birth and Indian ancestry. Because of the inclusion of the latter, some estimates put the Indian diaspora as large as 30 million. The largest group is in the USA.



▲ **Figure 6.27** Southall, the centre of London's Indian community

Potential disadvantages

In terms of disadvantages, the loss of workers with important skills – the so called ‘brain-drain’ effect – is of concern in many countries of origin. In extreme cases in some communities there may not be enough people to continue to farm effectively. Population structure can be adversely affected if migration is very gender-selective, and the loss of many young people can advance the ageing of the population.

The impact of migration on countries of destination

Any increase in the labour force is generally welcomed by businesses, particularly if migrants have skills that are in short supply. For example, health services in many HICs rely heavily on foreign nurses and doctors.

- » Greater competition in the labour force tends to limit wage rises, which helps keep inflation low. Low inflation is an important factor in economic stability.
- » Many people value an increase in cultural diversity, as it can enrich communities.
- » An influx of young migrants can help to reduce the rate of population ageing and lower the dependency ratio. This has a positive financial impact on countries.

The negative impact of immigration is more contentious. A significant influx of migrants can put pressure on the available housing stock, causing overcrowding and pushing up prices. Similarly, it will increase demand on health, education and other services to varying degrees. Trade unions often voice concerns over migration levels if they feel that their members are losing out on employment prospects because of an increase in the level of competition for work. In areas where there has been a significant change in the ethnic balance, tension between ethnic groups may increase.

Each receiving country has its own sources of immigrants. This is the result of historical, economic and geographical relationships. Earlier generations of migrants form networks that help new arrivals to overcome legal and other obstacles. The distribution of immigrants in receiving countries is uneven, with significant concentrations in economic core regions ([Figure 6.28](#)).



▲ **Figure 6.28** Chinatown, San Francisco – a major Chinese community in an American city

The impact of migration on migrants themselves

The prospect of higher wages, a wider choice of job opportunities and the chance to develop new skills are all important attractions to potential migrants. For many, this will enable them to provide financial support for their families in the country of origin. Other benefits may also become apparent, such as developing language skills. Eventually, obtaining citizenship in their country of destination may allow migrants to bring family members from their country of origin to join them.

On the debit side, the financial cost of migration may be considerable, but this may be shared among family members in anticipation of the remittances to follow. For many migrants, by far the greatest cost is separation from family and friends in their home country. The ‘culture shock’ of settling in a new country may be lessened if migrants secure housing and employment in an established migrant community in their new country. The risk of exploitation is a real concern for many migrants, and receiving countries vary in how effectively they challenge such practices.

The World Development Report (2023) identified four major challenges and barriers that most migrants face:

- » **Uncertainty:** Dealing with unexpected and uncertain outcomes, including the possibility of unemployment, social isolation, psychological stress and harm during transit.
- » **Unfamiliarity:** Monetary and non-monetary costs associated with the language, social norms and culture of their destination society.
- » **Job search:** Qualifications, skills and experience gained in one country may not transfer easily to another country. Migrants often have no option but to ‘downgrade’ to lower-skill employment.
- » **Financing:** The upfront costs of migration, such as travel and relocation, visas, processing and payments

to intermediaries can be high. Such costs can vary widely across migration corridors.

Activities

- 1 State two positive and two negative impacts of international migration on countries of origin.
 - 2 Give three benefits of international migration for countries of destination.
 - 3 Present a brief analysis of [Figure 6.26 \(page 148\)](#).
 - 4 With reference to an example, explain the term 'diaspora'.
 - 5 Discuss the four major challenges and barriers to migration identified in the World Development Report, 2023.
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The different approaches to managing international migration

International migration is a major global issue. Today, few countries favour a large influx of migrants, for a variety of issues. Within individual countries, attitudes to immigration can vary considerably. Attitudes tend to harden when economies are going through difficult periods and become more relaxed when economic conditions are good. Countries sometimes make incoming international migration more difficult for political and other reasons, and then find themselves short of labour in key economic sectors. Such a situation may be due not just to harsher barriers put up to deter incoming migrants, but also because existing migrants feel unwelcome and return home or migrate to another country.

The International Organization for Migration (IOM) is the leading international organisation for migration. It works to:

- » advance understanding of migration issues
- » assist in the challenges of migration management.

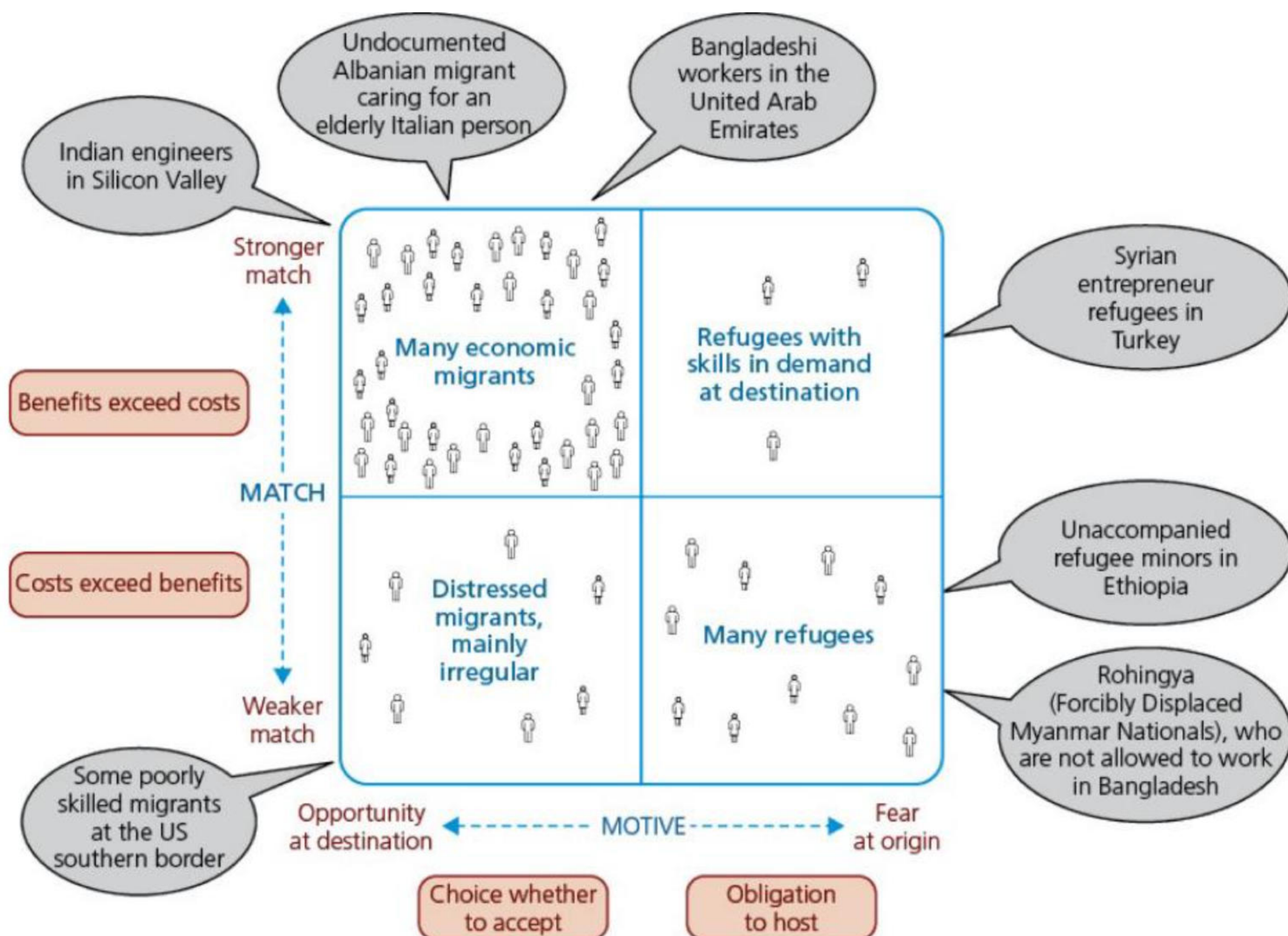
The IOM works with other international organisations to try to broker disputes between countries about population movements, particularly with regard to refugees and illegal immigration. In general, developing countries want their populations to have greater migration access to developed countries. In contrast, developed countries have tended to tighten controls on immigration.

International migration is a politically sensitive issue in many countries. There are clear examples in Europe and Africa:

- » Within the EU, there is a contrast between the more welcoming approach of some countries to migrants escaping from conflict in the Middle East, Afghanistan and parts of Africa, compared to the harder line taken by countries such as Poland and Hungary, which openly state their concerns about **cultural identity**.
- » Environmental degradation and conflicts in parts of Africa have led to significant movements of people, which have placed severe pressures on already poor host countries.

Countries have an unequal role in establishing migration policies. Most origin countries have little influence on regulating migration. In contrast, destination countries define and regulate who crosses their borders, who is legally allowed to stay, and with what rights. Labour economics and international law provide the two main concepts ([Figure 6.29](#)) for understanding migration patterns and the design of appropriate migration policies:

- » Labour economics focuses on the match between migrants' skills and the labour requirements of destination countries.
- » Under international law, migrants' motives determine destination countries' obligations. Those who meet the criteria for refugee status are entitled to international protection under the 1951 Refugee Convention.



▲ **Figure 6.29** The Match and Motive Matrix: ‘Match’ determines the net gains of receiving migrants; ‘Motive’ determines their international protection needs

Figure 6.29 provides a useful framework for understanding and managing international migration. On the diagram, the ‘problem’ area is the lower-left quadrant. These are ‘distressed migrants’ who neither qualify as refugees nor are a strong employment match at their destination. The migratory routes of this group of people are often irregular and unsafe, posing considerable challenges for destination countries. In addition, where migrants stand in the Match and Motive Matrix depends, at least in part, on whether the migrant has the right to work at the level of his/her qualifications. For example, a migrant who is a qualified midwife in their country of origin might not satisfy the qualification criteria in a country of destination.

The World Development Report (2023) states that government policies should aim to both:

- » maximise the development gains of migration – for the migrants, the origin societies and the destination societies
- » provide refugees with adequate international protection.

A range of organisations have stressed the importance of increased cooperation between origin countries, transit countries (where relevant) and destination countries. For example, over the past decade there has been improved dialogue between the USA (a destination country) and a number of countries in Latin America that are either countries of origin or transit countries (or both).

Australia’s offshoring policy

Australia is the only country in the world to enforce a policy of mandatory detention and offshore processing for all asylum seekers who arrive without a valid visa. This policy is particularly aimed at people arriving in Australian territorial waters by boat. Currently there is a single offshore detention centre on the Pacific island nation of Nauru. Although this policy has been heavily criticised internationally, Australian governments have defended it as necessary to deter people traffickers who exploit desperate asylum seekers. The UK announced a similar policy in 2022, with offshore processing in Rwanda. Due to numerous legal challenges, no asylum seekers had been sent to Rwanda at the time of writing in 2024.

Activities

- 1 Name the leading international organisation for migration.
- 2 Write a brief analysis of [Figure 6.29 \(page 151\)](#).

Detailed specific example

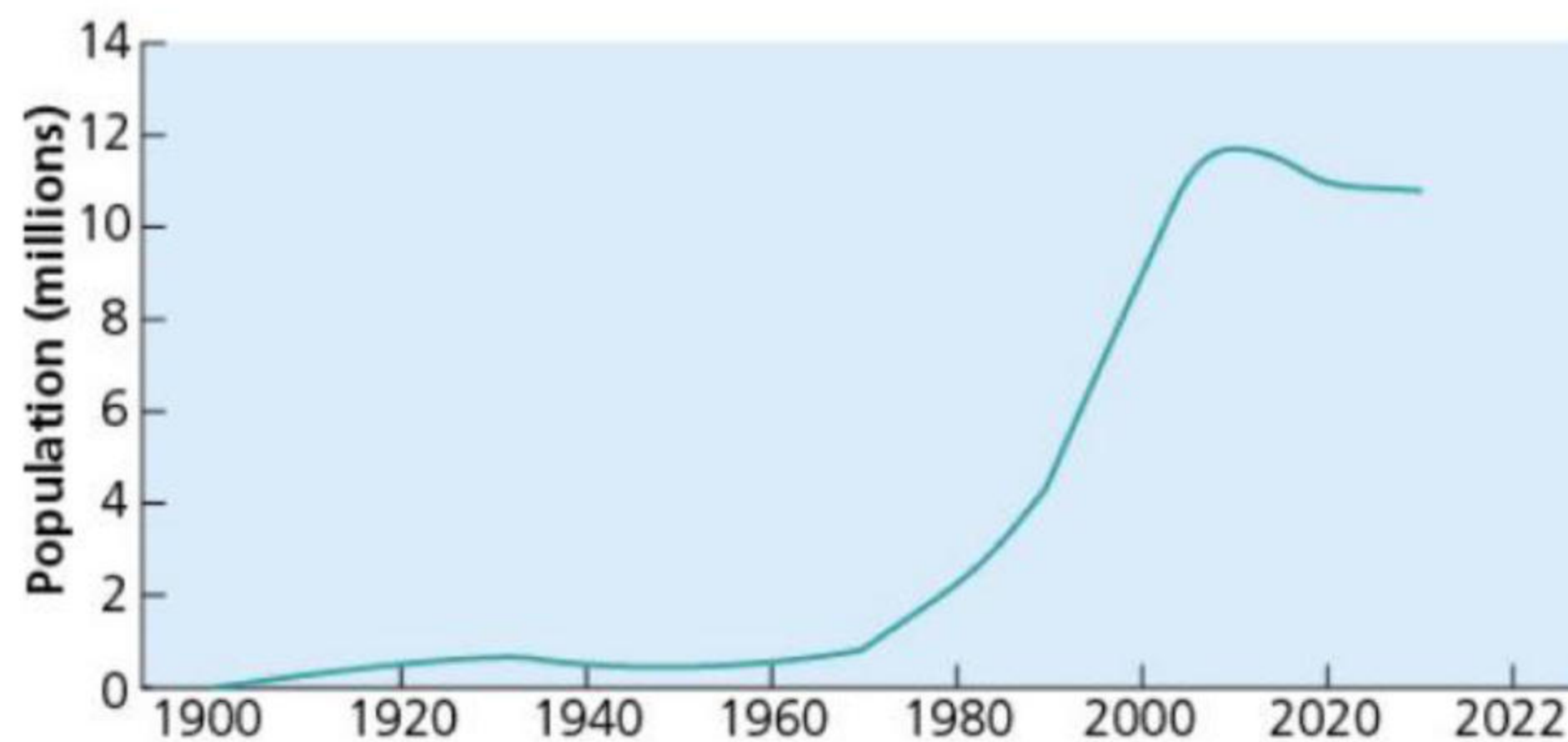
International migration from Mexico to the USA

One of the largest international migration streams in the world over the past 50 years has been from Mexico to the USA. This migration has formed the largest immigrant community in the world. It has been primarily a **labour migration**, and the result of the following push and pull factors:

- much higher average incomes in the USA
- lower unemployment rates in the USA
- faster growth of the labour force in Mexico, with significantly higher population growth than in the USA
- higher quality of life in the USA, according to most indicators.

Most migration from Mexico has taken place since the 1970s. However, previous surges occurred in the 1920s and 1950s, when the US government allowed the recruitment of Mexican workers as **guest workers**. As [Figure 6.30](#) shows, persistent **mass migration** between the two countries did not take hold until the late twentieth century. However, between 2010 and 2021 there was a decline of about 1 million (9 per cent) in the US–Mexican population. This has been attributed to two factors:

- Increased immigration enforcement by the US authorities ([Figure 6.31](#))
- A strengthening of the Mexican economy.



▲ **Figure 6.30** Changes in the Mexican-born population in the USA, 1900–2022



▲ **Figure 6.31** Fencing along the US border with Mexico, and the US Border Patrol

Mexicans accounted for about 24 per cent (10.7 million) of the 45.3 million foreign-born residents in the USA in 2021. However, for several years beginning in 2013, Mexico had been overtaken by India and China as the top country of origin for new immigrants to the USA. However, in 2021 Mexico was back in first place. The USA is the destination country for an astonishing 97 per cent of all Mexican emigrants, and 8 per cent of all people born in Mexico were living in the USA in 2020. Canada and Spain are the next most popular destinations for Mexican emigrants.

There is a very strong concentration of the US–Mexican population in particular states. For the 2015–19 period, most immigrants from Mexico lived in California (36 per cent), Texas (22 per cent), Illinois (6 per cent) and Arizona (5 per cent). The next six most populous states – Florida, Washington, Georgia, North Carolina, Colorado and Nevada – accounted for an additional 13 per cent of the Mexican-born population. The US cities with the largest number of Mexicans were the greater metropolitan areas of Los Angeles, Chicago, Dallas and Houston.

Within urban areas, the Mexican population is concentrated in areas of poor housing and low average income. In more peripheral areas, the Mexican population is largely found in low-cost housing areas where proximity to farm employment is an important factor. The main reasons for this spatial distribution are:

- proximity to the US southern border with Mexico
- the location of demand for immigrant farm workers
- urban areas where the Mexican community is long-established.

[Table 6.14](#) shows that a far higher proportion of the Mexican-born population in the USA are in the economically active age group compared to the US-born population. Additionally, like other immigrant groups, Mexicans are more likely to be employed in low-paid unskilled and semi-skilled jobs that are unpopular with the US-born population. These are the so

called '3D' jobs – that is, jobs that are 'dirty, dangerous and dull/difficult'. The Mexican-born population is heavily represented in agriculture, construction, hospitality and catering, and in household services.

▼ **Table 6.14** The age distribution of the US population by origin, 2021

Age group	Mexican immigrants	US-born population
Under 18	3 per cent	25 per cent
18-64	85 per cent	59 per cent
65 and over	12 per cent	17 per cent

In the USA the Federation for American Immigration Reform (FAIR) has opposed large-scale immigration from Mexico and elsewhere, arguing that it:

- undermines the employment opportunities of low-skilled US workers
- has adverse environmental effects because of the increased population
- threatens established US cultural values.

Those opposed to FAIR see its actions as uncharitable and arguably racist. Such individuals and groups highlight the advantages that Mexican and other migrant groups have brought to the country. They stress:

- the long-term economic benefits of immigration to the US economy
- the historical role the USA has played in welcoming immigrants from difficult circumstances abroad.

Donald Trump was president of the USA 2017–21. While in office he promised to build a new 'wall' in an attempt to make illegal migration from Mexico much more difficult. Much of this illegal migration is not from Mexico itself, but from a range of countries in Latin America for which Mexico is their potential crossing point into the USA. By the time President Trump left office in 2021, new border infrastructure had been constructed only along a limited part of the border. The border and how it is monitored and enforced is a controversial issue in both the USA and Mexico.

The impact of migration on Mexico and on Mexican migrants

Sustained large-scale migration has had a range of impacts on Mexico, some of them clear and others debatable. Significant impacts include the high value of remittances, which totalled over US\$63 billion in 2023, more than any other country except India in that year. Remittances as a percentage of Mexico's GDP grew from 2 per cent in 2010 to 3.8 per cent in 2020, and to an estimated 4.5 per cent in 2023.

The Mexican economy in the two opening decades of this century (2000s and 2010s) has been more stable than in the 1980s and 1990s, when the country faced a number of serious economic crises.

There is little doubt that in the 1980s and 1990s (and earlier), migration to the USA:

- reduced unemployment pressure, as migrants tend to leave areas where unemployment is particularly high
- lowered pressure on the housing stock and public services
- supported the finances of many households and communities through remittances.

On the negative side, emigration has:

- changed the population structure of many communities due to the emigration of large numbers of young adults
- witnessed the loss of skilled and enterprising people
- depleted the agricultural workforce in areas where emigration has been dominated by young men, with women and children often taking the place of now-absent men in agriculture.

In recent decades, two important changes occurred to impact the strength of migration from Mexico. The significant loss of jobs in the USA in the 'Great Recession' of 2007–09 occurred in industries in which immigrants tend to be heavily represented. This encouraged some migrants to move back to Mexico. Secondly, the aftermath of the recession also made the USA a less attractive proposition to many potential migrants. On the Mexican side of the border, declining fertility had slowed the growth of the working age population. To an extent, smaller average family size reduced the need for migration as a means of family financial support.

An important characteristic of migration, which can be viewed as either positive or negative according to the observer's personal views, is the return of migrants to Mexico with changed values and attitudes. The new values and attitudes of returning migrants often clash with traditional views, particularly in more isolated rural communities.

In terms of individual migrants, the most successful movements tended to be from communities in Mexico where a **migrant culture** had become established and where strong diaspora communities had been built up in particular destinations in the USA. Mexican culture has had a sustained impact on many areas of the USA, particularly urban areas close to the border. As a result, many Mexican migrants find reassuring similarities between the two countries.

There is no doubt that the Mexican population of the USA has undergone a process of assimilation over time. There are three facets to assimilation:

- Economic
- Social
- Political.

Assimilation tends to occur in the order presented above, with economic assimilation occurring first. While many migrants from Mexico would be in the low-skilled category, their children and grandchildren usually aspire to, and gain, higher qualifications and skills. Such economic mobility results in greater social contact with the mainstream population. Eventually, more people from migrant populations get involved in politics and the migrant community gains better political representation.

The migration status of an individual migrant is of great importance to the choices that individual can make. Because of its very nature, it is difficult for the authorities to be precise about illegal immigration. In 2019, the Pew Research Center estimated that 77 per cent of US immigrants were 'Documented' and 23 per cent 'Undocumented'. Nearly half of

all immigrants have become US citizens.

Migration and sustainability

The literature on the relationship between migration and sustainability often stresses that these issues are frequently managed separately by government at all scales. The potential impact of migration on sustainability increases with the level of migration. The impacts are environmental, economic and social, and occur in the countries of both origin and destination. In recent decades, immigration into the USA has been at very high levels. However, Mexico has also been affected by large numbers of migrants moving through the country from further south in Latin America. The huge scale of this movement has resulted in increasing cooperation between the US and Mexican governments, and also between other governments in Latin America.

The US Strategy to Address the Root Causes of Migration in Central America aims to establish more prosperous, safe and democratic conditions, so that potential migrants are not compelled to leave their home countries. However, what the USA can realistically do at scale to limit the desire of people in a range of Latin American countries to travel north remains to be seen.

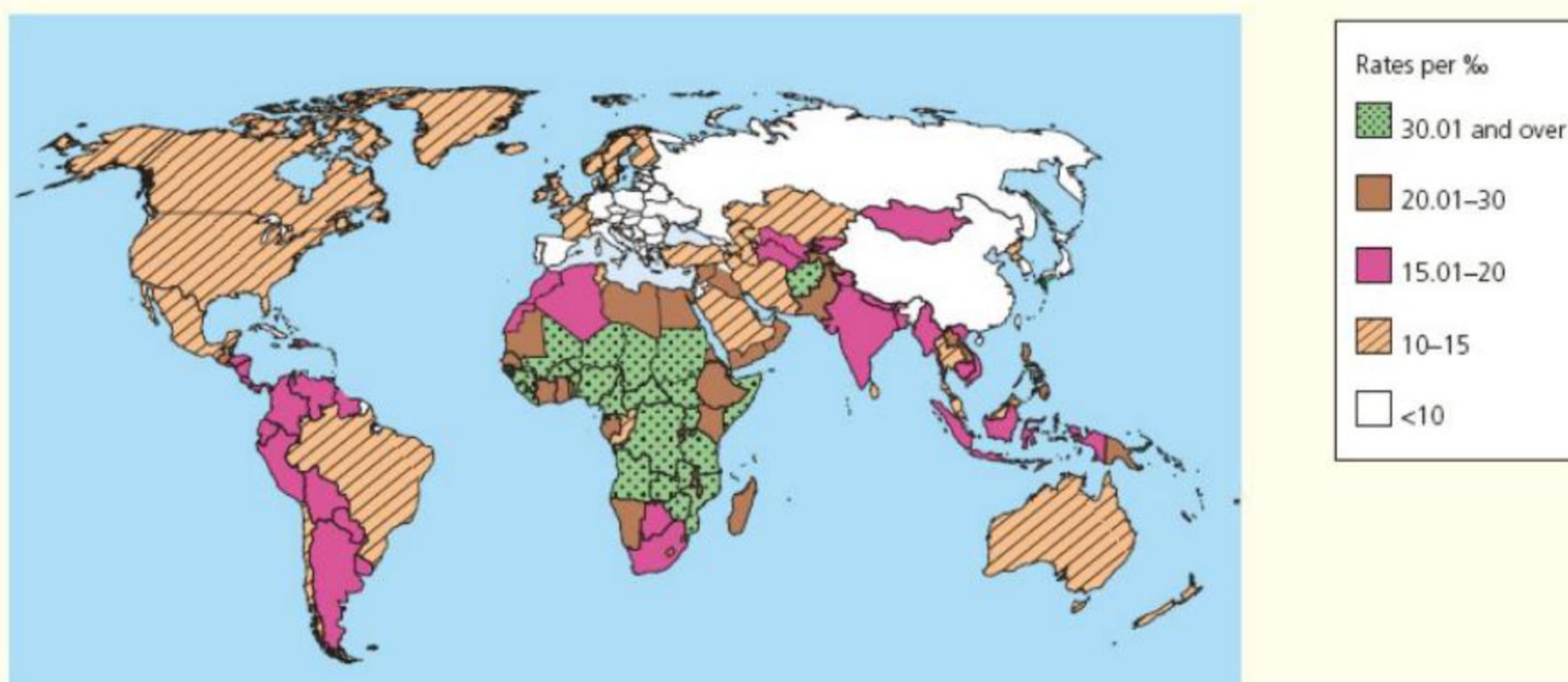
In recent years more attention has been directed to immigration governance in the USA. There is a growing recognition that the contribution of migrants to US society tends to increase with integration. For example, access to better education gives migrants greater opportunity to realise their potential.

Activities

- 1 Describe the changes in the Mexican-born population in the USA illustrated by [Figure 6.30 \(page 152\)](#).
- 2 Outline the main factors that have encouraged migration from Mexico to the USA.
- 3 Present a brief analysis of [Table 6.14 \(page 153\)](#).
- 4 Why has the Mexican-born population in the USA fallen in recent times?

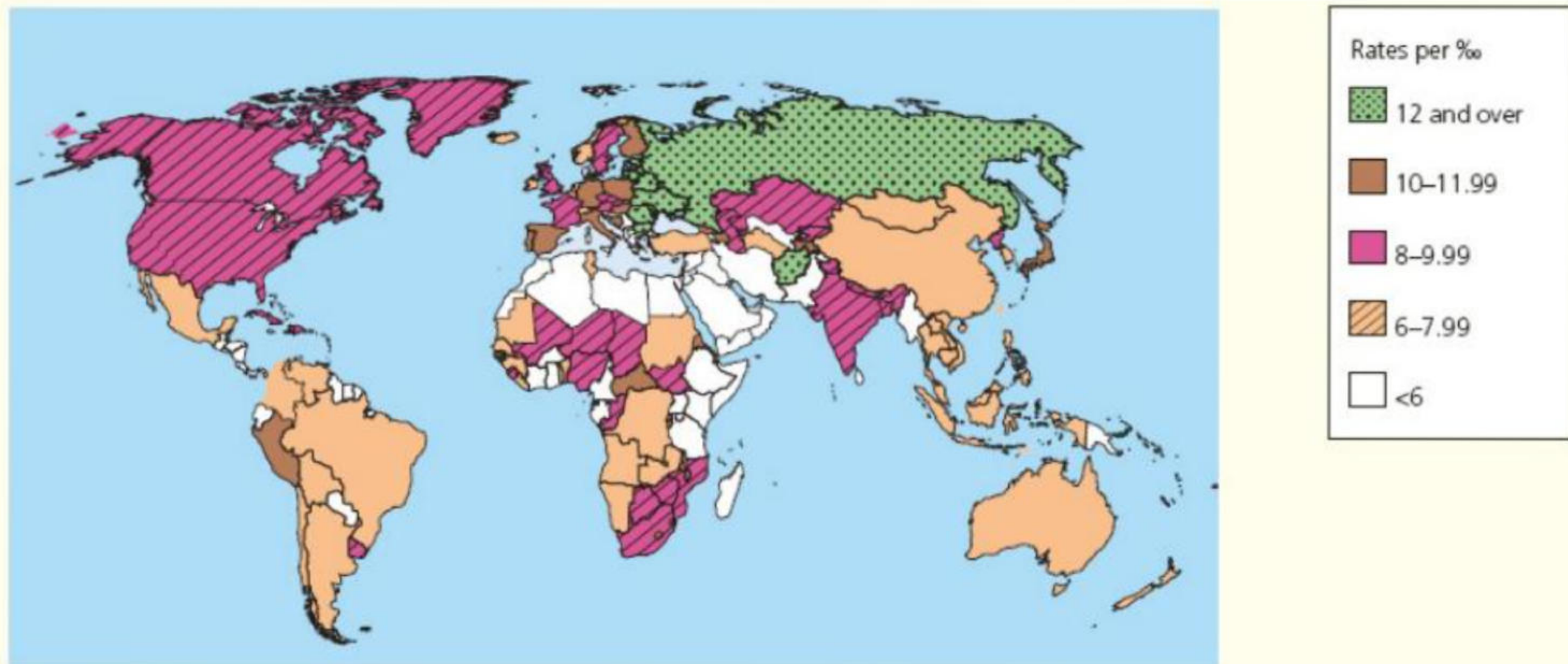
Practice questions

- 1 [Figure 6.32](#) shows global birth rates in 2023.



▲ **Figure 6.32** Global birth rates, 2023

- a Define the term 'birth rate'. [1]
 - b Describe the pattern of global birth rates in 2023. [3]
 - c Suggest reasons for the high birth rates in your answer to (b). [3]
- 2 [Figure 6.33](#) shows the global pattern of death rates in 2023.
 - a Define the term 'death rate'. [1]
 - b Describe the global pattern of death rates in 2023. [3]
 - c Suggest reasons for the high death rates in your answer to (b). [3]



▲ **Figure 6.33** The global pattern of death rates, 2023

- 3 a Define the term 'population structure'. [1]
b Explain how rural-to-urban migration causes changes in population structure. [3]
- 4 Assess the advantages and disadvantages of ageing populations. [7]